

Course Introduction & Expectations

What this course is, how it works, and how to succeed

Gerrish School of Business · Endicott College · Fall 2026

Connect to Prior Knowledge

In Lesson 01 you set up Microsoft 365 and created your BUS123 folder structure in OneDrive. Now that your professional digital workspace is ready, this lesson introduces the course itself — what you will learn, how your work will be assessed, and what is expected of you each class period. Understanding the structure of BUS123 from the start is one of the most practical steps you can take toward succeeding in it.

Concept Overview

Course Structure: Three Learning Tracks

BUS123 is organized into three parallel tracks that run throughout the semester. Each class period draws from one or more tracks depending on the topic.

Track	Name	Focus
1	Introduction	Office 365, OneDrive, digital fluency, professional file habits
2	Excel Skills	Formulas, functions, data management, charts, workbook design
3	Business Math	Payroll, discounts, markup, breakeven, interest, taxes, inventory

The Four Case Study Companies

Every worksheet, example, and homework problem in BUS123 uses one of four fictional companies. These companies provide consistent context so you always understand why you are doing the math — not just how.

Company	Industry	Primary Topics
Tidal Goods Co.	Retail	Inventory, COGS, markup, markdown pricing
Meridian Advisory Group	Financial Services	Payroll, TVM, interest, tax, loan math
Anchor & Oak Events	Event Planning	Breakeven, cash flow, labor costs, pricing

Harborside Medical Center	Healthcare	Data analysis, payer mix %, payroll complexity
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Grading and Standards-Based Learning

BUS123 uses a Standards-Based Learning (SBL) grading system. Rather than scoring work as a percentage, each assignment is evaluated against a specific learning standard on a 4-point proficiency scale.

Score	Level	What It Means
4	Exceeds	Mastery beyond expectations — applies skills in new, unfamiliar contexts
3	Meets	Grade-level expectation — concepts applied correctly and completely
2	Approaching	Partial understanding — some errors or gaps present
1	Beginning	Limited understanding — significant gaps remain

■ A score of 3 (Meets) is the goal for every assignment. Level 4 requires you to apply skills in contexts not directly covered in class — this is what the Challenge tab in your workbooks is designed for.

Workbook Structure and the Formula First Rule

Every Excel workbook in this course follows the same tab structure. Understanding this structure before your first class activity saves time and confusion.

Tab	Name	Purpose
1	START HERE	Instructions, learning objectives, and how to use the workbook
2	Main Activity	Primary exercise — yellow cells are your input cells
3	Challenge	Optional Level 4 stretch exercise — earns Exceeds proficiency
4	Formula Reference Card	Every Excel formula and function introduced in this lesson

■ The Formula First Rule: workbooks never tell you which Excel function to use. Read the context clues, consult the Formula Reference Card, and choose the right function yourself — just like a real analyst would.



Quick Reference — Course Logistics

Topic	Detail
Class format	50-minute periods — lecture + in-class workshop every session
No textbook	All materials on Canvas and GitHub — free, always accessible
Grading	35% In-Class · 25% Homework · 20% Quizzes · 20% Projects
Submission types	Track 1: Canvas Quiz (auto-graded) · Track 2: Excel file upload
File naming	Always include your last name: Lastname_M01_L02_Activity.xlsx
AI policy	AI for learning = permitted. AI completing your work = academic integrity violation
Canvas notifications	Enable email alerts for Announcements and Grading — required



Check Your Understanding

Answer these 7 questions after reading.

1. Name the three learning tracks in BUS123 and describe the focus of each in one sentence.

2. A student saves their completed Excel homework to their Desktop instead of OneDrive, then submits it on Canvas. The file name is "HW1.xlsx". Identify two problems with this approach.

3. What does a proficiency score of 3 (Meets) mean in the Standards-Based Learning system? How does it differ from a 4?

4. You open your Excel workbook and see that the answer in a yellow cell is already filled in with a number — not a formula. Should you leave it or fix it? Explain.

5. Describe the four case study companies used in this course and match each to its primary topic area.

6. A classmate uses ChatGPT to complete their Excel homework and submits it. Is this permitted under the course AI policy? Explain your reasoning.

7. Where in Canvas would you go to: (a) find this week's lesson materials, (b) check your current grade, and (c) submit a homework file?

Key Vocabulary

Standards-Based Learning (SBL)

A grading system that measures proficiency against defined learning standards rather than assigning percentage scores. Uses a 4-point scale: Beginning, Approaching, Meets, and Exceeds.

Proficiency Scale

The 4-point scoring rubric used in this course. Level 3 (Meets) is the grade-level expectation. Level 4 (Exceeds) requires applying skills in unfamiliar contexts.

Case Study Company

One of four fictional businesses used throughout BUS123 to provide real-world context for math and Excel exercises: Tidal Goods Co., Meridian Advisory Group, Anchor & Oak Events, and Harborside Medical Center.

Canvas

The Learning Management System (LMS) used at Endicott College. Students access lessons, submit assignments, take quizzes, and view grades through Canvas.

Formula First Rule

The expectation that all calculations in Excel workbooks are built as formulas using cell references and functions — never as hardcoded numbers typed directly into result cells.

Yellow Cell

A cell with yellow fill formatting that indicates where students should type their input or formula. Only yellow cells should be modified unless instructed otherwise.

Challenge Tab

The optional third tab in every BUS123 workbook. Contains Level 4 problems that require applying skills in new contexts — corresponds to the Exceeds proficiency level.